

Mediating Art in the Digital Age: A Critical Evaluation of Digital Curation and Audience Engagement at M+ Museum

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ABSTRACT

The global trend of museum digital transformation has grown widely throughout the world, especially after the pandemic. Facing the reality of losing onsite audiences and the change in the way the public learns due to technological upgrades, many museums have recognized the new situation and proactively embraced digital technologies through various practices. For this research, I chose M+ Museum in Hong Kong as the selected case study.

INTRODUCTION

In the post-pandemic era, online-offline integrated museum practices have become the norm due to new attention gathered from digital media like social media, digital equipment, and new technologies. Digital tools are no longer seen as supplementary but as core infrastructure to engage younger, digitally native audiences. Thus, the global cultural heritage sector has undergone a paradigm shift from object-centred display to experience-centred engagement, with digital technology emerging as a core driver of museum transformation and public accessibility. Museums like M+ are using more and more digital technologies to enlarge the audience's cultural experience both in and out of the museum.

In Hong Kong, two main cultural institutions play an essential role in positioning the city as an "East-meets-West centre for international cultural exchange": the Leisure and Cultural Services Department (LCSD) and the West Kowloon Cultural District (WKCD). The post-pandemic period has accelerated the normalisation of online-offline (OMO) museum models in Hong Kong. As Hong Kong's flagship museum of visual culture, M+ Museum represents the most comprehensive and resourceful digital practice in the local museum sector, making it a representative and critical case for analysis. Dedicated to collecting, exhibiting, and interpreting visual art, design and architecture, moving image, and Hong Kong

visual culture of the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, M+ is a nexus for researching and presenting contemporary visual culture, inspiring thought and curiosity.

This paper critically examines M+ Museum's digital applications across two core functions—content conveyance and audience education—and proposes theoretically grounded improvements to address existing gaps.

The research is guided by the following questions: In what ways do integrated online and offline digital applications at M+ Museum mediate and extend the narrative of individual artworks and broader curatorial research? To what extent do digital technologies at M+ Museum foster meaningful, educationally valuable audience engagement, rather than superficial, entertainment-focused interaction? What can be developed to strengthen the curatorial integration, inclusivity, and educational impact of M+ Museum's digital ecosystem? By answering these three questions, this paper conducts a systematic evaluation of M+'s digital practices.

Literature Review & Theoretical Framework

In today's changing world, museums must become agents of change and development by redefining their missions, goals, functions, and strategies (Sharma, 2018). Therefore, digital curation becomes an inevitable mode of curating in this scenario. Digital curation is not merely the digitisation of physical exhibitions but a curatorial practice that reconstructs artwork narratives and knowledge production through digital media. The concept of digital curation must be understood within a longer history of shifting curatorial authority. As Lopes (2020) observes, curatorial practice has been fundamentally reshaped by changing public expectations: "the curator has proceeded from a figure of intellectual authority, and a custodian of cultural and artistic objects safely kept behind the glass case in a museum, to a cultural mediator who seeks new forms to engage the audience with artists and objects through museum displays and exhibitions" (p. 124). This theoretical framework underpins the analysis of M+ Museum's digital practices in the following case study.

In traditional museums, audiences are more like passive viewers who walk through different rooms, watching artworks passively hanging on the wall. However, museums today efficiently integrate the digital ecosystem as a synergistic system rather than two separate channels, where physical spaces and digital platforms complement and reinforce each other. As a tool for breaking the spatial and textual limits of physical labels, digital media enables multi-layered delivery of artwork context and curatorial research to audiences with different knowledge levels. Additional digital content, like creation processes, artist interviews, and cross-exhibit thematic connections, has greatly deepened the audience's understanding of the exhibition and strengthened community cohesion.

Grounded in constructivist learning theory, interactive digital tools transform visitors from passive viewers into active inquirers, enhancing learning outcomes in informal museum settings. Digital tools have reshaped the museum-audience relationship, moving visitors from being passive recipients of curatorial knowledge to active participants who can interact with collections, contribute content, and even take part in co-creating curatorial narratives (NEMO Working Group LEM – The Learning Museum, 2023). This aligns with the core principle of constructivism: that knowledge is not passively absorbed but actively constructed by learners through engagement with their environment. Beyond expanding participatory possibilities, digital technologies also enhance the accessibility and personalisation of museum education, allowing audiences to engage with content at their own pace and according to their own interests, regardless of physical location. This theoretical foundation frames the subsequent analysis of how M+ Museum leverages digital tools to deliver educational and engaging experiences for its audiences.

Meanwhile, scholars have discussed that most online interactions remain at the level of superficial browsing rather than deep participation, and this may cause inconvenience for elderly, disabled, and non-tech-savvy audiences. Besides, museums should be cautious when choosing digital media so that they do not just transform artworks into decorative technology that adds no curatorial value. Current local research mostly focuses on technical introductions or industry overviews, lacking in-depth critical

evaluations of single institutions and evidence-based actionable proposals. Therefore, this paper intends to address this gap through a "description–critique–proposal" analytical structure.

Case Analysis: Digital Practices for Content Conveyance

Onsite digital devices

In M+ Museum, multiple digital devices are used frequently to convey content that is difficult to explain with physical objects or to re-showcase a scene that is impossible to see otherwise. For example, in the exhibition "Making It Matters," they use a digital screen to recreate the process of a burning chair.



In this way, the audience can easily see the whole process of the burning and understand the final appearance. On one hand, digital practices like this are quite effective in unpacking curatorial themes and explaining the logical connections between artworks; on the other hand, they turn static artworks into a visible experience which will catch the audience's attention and make them spend more time delving into the message that the artist truly wants to express. In this case, the audience is no longer a passive viewer but a proactive explorer.

Apart from the digital devices displayed in almost every exhibition in M+, the museum also creates many immersive experience spaces for the audience to sit and enjoy the artwork. For example, in the M+ Sigg

Collection, they used various digital devices, including digital screens, headphones, and projections, to build a whole immersive space relevant to the exhibition theme. Most of them are placed with other objects or art pieces to build a corner where the audience can chill and peacefully enjoy the artwork. López-Rodríguez et al. (2025) explain that immersive digital experiences are defined by their ability to "envelop the viewer, stimulating multiple senses" and facilitate active, embodied interaction rather than passive visual contemplation (p. 1). This logic underpins many of M+'s in-gallery digital installations, which aim to deepen visitor connection to exhibited works.



-Online application

The official application, WestK, includes comprehensive information for the public, including GPS-triggered audio, curator-narrated commentary, themed visiting routes, supplementary archival materials, and multi-language support, through which visitors with different interests and knowledge backgrounds can easily find the information they need. Firstly, the audio guide for every ongoing exhibition is available on the app. This has greatly facilitated visitors' experiences and provided them with a comprehensive guided tour, playing an essential role in message conveyance and art education because of the widespread use of mobile phones. Mobile digital guides extend the curator's role as a cultural mediator, as they allow curatorial research and interpretive arguments to be delivered directly to individual visitors, unconstrained by the physical and textual limits of printed gallery labels (Lopes, 2020). In terms of content conveyance, this system fundamentally expands the informational boundaries of

physical wall labels, where printed text is limited to brief factual descriptions. The digital guide can elaborate on the intellectual logic of curatorial themes, trace conceptual connections across disparate artworks, and present the full contextual background of the museum's curatorial research.



Audio Guide

Key in the audio stop number or scan the QR code on the object labels in the M+ galleries. Listen to interviews and audio description of the objects through Cantonese, English, and Mandarin audio tracks. Headsets and mobile devices are available to borrow. Please visit the Ground Floor Information Desk for full details.

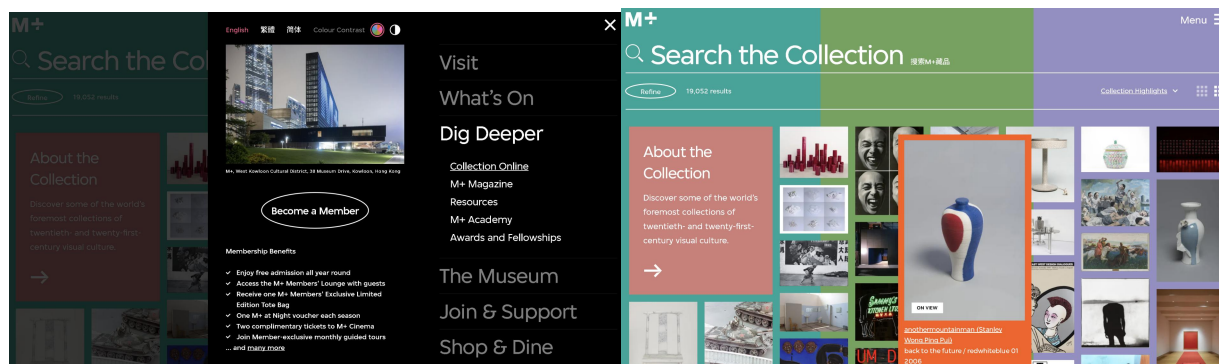
- [Access the in-gallery audio guide using your mobile device](#)
- [Explore our archived audio guide content](#)

Secondly, the efficient update of ongoing events is very important in forming an art-centered community, which highly corresponds with the mission of M+. The M+ mobile app serves as a core in-gallery digital mediator, delivering both personalized interpretation and community-oriented event programming. Spallazzo and Mariani (2021) note that digitally organized museum activities foster both strong social ties among existing acquaintances and weak social ties among strangers, all united by cultural content as a shared point of connection. For M+, embedding event sign-up within the same app used for gallery navigation removes friction for participation and turns casual one-time visitors into repeat attendees.



Online archive

Beyond in-gallery digital tools that support on-site visits, M+'s online collection archive and open-access research resources constitute the most academically rigorous channel of content conveyance. It systematically translates curatorial research findings into publicly accessible digital assets, breaking the temporal and capacity limits of physical exhibitions to serve casual visitors, art enthusiasts, and independent researchers alike. It has a "Dig Deeper" section on its website, giving layered content to art enthusiasts and professionals. Open online archives serve as a powerful informal learning resource, as they allow users to conduct self-directed inquiry at their own pace, following personal research interests rather than the fixed narrative structure of a curated exhibition (NEMO Working Group LEM – The Learning Museum, 2023). Apart from that, the digital archive also helps in preserving and disseminating curatorial research permanently, even after physical exhibitions close, and extends the lifespan and reach of curatorial scholarship. While this digital archive represents a significant achievement in academic transparency and public access, it also remains underutilized by general audiences, a gap that will be examined in the subsequent critical evaluation.



Critical Evaluation: Engagement Effect and Educational Outcomes

M+'s digital ecosystem has achieved notable success in expanding public access and providing tiered educational content that serves casual visitors, art enthusiasts, and academic researchers alike. Benefiting from this digital ecosystem, not only do non-local and disabled audiences get access to art and culture, but the cultural institution itself also breaks geographical and temporal barriers and makes its voice heard in public. Through immersive and interactive designs, the audience enhances their resonance with artworks

and builds a connection with both the artist and the institution, which can lead to more future visits. This is how the community gets closer and bonded together. M+'s digital ecosystem does not only focus on a certain level of audience; instead, it is built on a layered system where diverse information needs are met, from casual browsing to in-depth research.

Besides, M+'s creative social media campaigns during exhibition periods play an essential role in enlarging the audience. Their digital and social media strategies have effectively engaged younger audiences, turning museum content into shareable cultural capital and lowering the threshold for first-time visitors. Through social media platforms like Xiaohongshu and Instagram, M+ has gained a large audience from the younger generation, many of whom post their pictures on social media after seeing an exhibition. A key driver of this youth appeal is the sharability of museum content and the amazing visual effects. For young social media users, posting aesthetically curated museum visits functions as a form of lifestyle branding and cultural capital, generating organic peer-to-peer promotion that is far more persuasive than official marketing (Chen et al., 2025).

Most importantly, this digital presence lowers the psychological barrier to entry for those visiting a museum for the first time. By presenting art in accessible, relatable formats, it demystifies contemporary visual culture and reduces the perception that museums are elite, intimidating spaces reserved for specialist audiences (NEMO Working Group LEM – The Learning Museum, 2023).

Meanwhile, this social-media-driven engagement carries inherent critical risks. As Akpang (2021) argues, the dominance of social media as a distribution channel has reshaped contemporary art from an intellectual and aesthetic practice into a marketable cultural commodity, where shareability and visual spectacle are prioritized over the depth of curatorial research and the intrinsic value of the creative act. For M+, this tension is visible where many young visitors attend exhibitions primarily to produce social media content rather than to engage with curatorial information. In this sense, while digital outreach has successfully expanded the museum's youth audience, it has also shifted the terms of engagement away

from intellectual depth and toward consumable spectacle. This is one of the key limitations of M+'s current digital strategy.

Another limitation comes from the wide use of applications and other online platforms, which do not only bring convenience but also address the digital divide, resulting in accessibility barriers for elderly visitors and people with disabilities. Complex app interfaces and interactive device operations are an obstacle for the elderly to fully engage with, and the over-reliance on personal smartphones can exclude visitors without suitable devices at the same time.

Improvement Suggestions

Building on the critical evaluation, this section outlines four targeted, theoretically grounded proposals to strengthen the curatorial integration, educational impact, and social inclusivity of M+'s digital ecosystem.

Facing these two main limitations, M+ should see digital curation as an integral part of curatorial practice, not a post-production step, and invite dedicated digital curators into exhibition project teams from the earliest research conception stage, rather than engaging them only for late-stage installation and promotion. When digital specialists participate in early research discussions, they can identify opportunities for digital media to advance curatorial arguments, rather than merely illustrate them.

To bridge the digital divide, M+ should apply universal design principles across all digital products, including a simplified senior app mode, free loaner guide devices, and full screen-reader and sign language compatibility. Following the Smithsonian Institution's accessibility strategy and ICOM guidelines, this ensures digital tools expand rather than restrict equitable cultural access.

To fully realize the academic and educational value of its digital archive, M+ should expand its open-access collection platform to include primary curatorial research materials, transforming the archive from a basic object database into a comprehensive public research infrastructure. For general audiences, curator research notes and recommended reading lists can be added. Besides, M+ can implement a tiered open research structure for each collection entry, explaining the context of individual artworks in accessible language.

Collectively, these proposals reorient M+'s digital strategy around its core mission of research, education, and inclusion, rather than technological novelty or marketing performance.

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